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Pixar Out-Disneys Disney



CRICKETER AND COMMENTATOR Sunil Gavaskar was once asked how he felt when Allan Border crossed his world record for the most number of runs in Test cricket. He replied: "Hundreds of people have reached the summit of Mount Everest, but nobody has ever forgotten Edmund Hillary and Tensing Norgay."

Walt Disney is in a similar situation these days—the challenger has arrived, but we never forget Disney. Pixar, the company that apprenticed under Disney and created movies, such as *Toy Story* and *Finding Nemo*, now threatens to upstage Disney's unchallenged monopoly in the computer graphics (CG) animation features space.

Freelance writer Austin Bunn's excellent business and technology sketch of Pixar Animation Studios, in the June issue of *Wired* magazine, chronicles the rise of Pixar, and poses the question: Will Pixar now be the master, and Disney the apprentice?

An excerpt from the piece:

By any standards, Pixar Animation Studios has reached infinity and beyond. From 1995's *Toy Story*—the world's first all-CG feature—to last year's *Finding Nemo*, Pixar's five hermetically crafted movies have grossed a staggering \$2.5 billion at the box office, making it the most successful film studio, picture for picture, of all time. "You have to take your hat off to them," says Neil Braun, head of CG-animation company Vanguard and former president of the NBC Television Network. In the history of film, there's just one precedent for this level of economic triumph, this ability to add to the American childhood's beloved cast of characters: Disney Animation Studios.

Pixar hasn't just turned into the new Disney. It has out-Disneyed Disney, becoming the apprentice that schooled the sorcerer. Pixar's most talented animators grew up admiring Disney, worked at the sketching tables in Burbank, and went on to crib the company's DNA. Pixar's story development process as well as its internal lexicon—including sweatbox, when the director critiques individual animations, and plus-ing, heaping more and more good ideas on a structure that's already working—come directly from the 'House That Mickey Built'. Both companies are technical pioneers: Disney imbued 2-D cel animation with comedy and heartbreak; Pixar coaxed empathy from digital effects. Now the flipbook animation style that made the Magic Kingdom a powerhouse is fading to black: Disney's *Home on the Range*, released in April, is the last fully 2-D production for the studio, and competitors like DreamWorks are retraining illustrators to be 3-D mouse jockeys. Pixar's digital animation is the wave of the future.



Read the entire story at www.wired.com/wired/archive/12.06/pixar.html

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Does Google Show Other Corporates the Way?



WE ALL KNOW Google is the best, but can it be a role model for the rest of the world's corporates? Melanie Warner from *Business 2.0* provided the answer:

The Wisdom of Google Lesson 1: Don't sell your soul to the highest bidder

From the start, Brin and Page took the high road with advertising. While other search engines were secretly

tucking paid advertiser sites into their listings—a process called "paid inclusion"—Google decided that the only parts of its site it would ever sell to advertisers would be clearly marked

"Sponsored Links" sections at the top and side of the page. The founders also refused to allow banners and pop-up ads. Brin, in particular, was adamant about this. He hated using search sites like AltaVista and Yahoo! and waiting while a colorful, inane ad lumbered across the screen.

Lesson 2: Create a culture of risk taking

Now that Google dominates Web search, it's easy to forget how strange its approach really was in 1998. The notion that the world needed another search engine—there were already at least 10—was absurd. Though the quality of search results was declining as the Internet swelled, most people didn't seem to care. Even technologically savvy people like Kordestani were content with their search engines. "I was using Yahoo! and Netscape," (Omid) Kordestani (head of sales at Google) admits. "In some ways, you just didn't know any better."

Conventional logic held that the ability to do searches was, at best, a feature of some bigger, fancier product. Google stripped its search engine down to the point where it looked naked. No news, no weather, no horoscopes. Just a goofy logo in Romper Room colors, and a search bar floating on an empty page.

Such a counterintuitive move branded Page and Brin as serious mavericks, which in turn attracted kindred spirits. It's partly why Google CEO Eric Schmidt was so keen on taking the job. Schmidt tagged himself as something of a risk taker when he quit as Sun's (SUNW) chief technology officer to join the ailing networking company Novell. Brin delights in saying that he and Page chose Schmidt because "he was the only candidate who had been to Burning Man."

The risk-taking culture at Google is fostered by a policy that encourages engineers to spend 20 percent of their time working on personal projects that may or may not benefit the company. The point is to get people thinking creatively and independently...

Even the aspects of Google that make it seem more like a kindergarten than a company worth billions—the lava lamps, the Segway scooters, the remote-control UFOs Brin and Page bought at Costco a while back for no particular reason—send an important message. They remind people that companies don't have to operate the way everyone thinks they're supposed to.

Read the entire story at www.business2.com/b2/web/articles/0,17863,634420,00.html?ref=specials